

Cyprian Ep. 55 (LA-EN)

Epistula LV ad Antonianum, de Cornelio et Novatiano (*Letter 55 to Antonianus, on Cornelius and Novatian*)

by St. Cyprian of Carthage († 258), written A.D. 251/252

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- *Latin text: W. Hartel's critical edition, CSEL III.2 (Vienna, 1871), pp. 629–630 and 642–643, transcribed from the page images; Hartel's orthography (adque, conpellit, quisque for quisquis) retained. In the older numbering of the Ante-Nicene Fathers translation this letter is Ep. 51.*
- *Translation of the original text performed by AI (claude-fable-5).*
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- *Selection pages: CSEL III.2, pp. 629-630 (cc. 8-9) and 642-643 (c. 24)*

Chapter 8 — Cornelius's election and its confirmation (CSEL p. 629–630)

<i>Latin (CSEL III.2)</i>	<i>English</i>
Venio iam nunc, frater carissime, ad personam Corneli collegae nostri, ut Cornelium nobiscum uerius noueris, non de malignorum et detrahentium mendacio, sed de Dei iudicio qui episcopum eum fecit et coepiscoporum testimonio quorum numerus uniuersus per totum mundum concordii unanimitate consensit. nam quod Cornelium carissimum nostrum Deo et Christo et	I come now, dearest brother, to the person of Cornelius our colleague, that you may know Cornelius more truly with us — not from the lies of the malicious and the detractors, but from the judgment of God, who made him bishop, and from the testimony of his fellow bishops, whose whole number through the whole world has consented with concordant unanimity. For — a thing which commends our dearest Cornelius to God and to Christ and to His Church,

<i>Latin (CSEL III.2)</i>	<i>English</i>
ecclesiae eius, item consacerdotibus cunctis laudabili praedicatione commendat, non iste ad episcopatum subito peruenit, sed per omnia ecclesiastica officia promotus et in diuinis administrationibus Dominum saepe promeritus ad sacerdotii sublime fastigium cunctis religionis gradibus ascendit. tunc deinde episcopatum ipsum nec postulauit nec uoluit, nec ut ceteri quos adrogantiae et superbiae suae tumor inflat inuasit, sed quietus alias et modestus et quales esse consuerunt qui ad hunc locum diuinitus eliguntur, pro pudore uirginalis continentiae suae et pro humilitate ingenitae sibi et custoditae uerecundiae non ut quidam uim fecit ut episcopus fieret, sed ipse uim passus est ut episcopatum coactus exciperet. Et factus est episcopus a plurimis collegis nostris qui tunc in urbe Roma aderant, qui ad nos litteras honorificas et laudabiles et testimonio suae praedicationis inlustres de eius ordinatione miserunt. factus est autem Cornelius episcopus de Dei et Christi eius iudicio, de clericorum paene omnium testimonio, de plebis quae tunc adfuit suffragio, de sacerdotum antiquorum et bonorum uirorum collegio, cum nemo ante se factus esset, cum Fabiani locus id est cum locus Petri et gradus cathedrae sacerdotalis uacaret: quo occupato et de Dei uoluntate adque omnium nostrum consensione firmato, quisque iam episcopus fieri uoluerit foris fiat necesse est nec habeat ecclesiasticam ordinationem qui ecclesiae non tenet unitatem. quisque ille fuerit multum de se licet iactans et sibi plurimum uindicans,	and likewise to all his fellow priests, with praiseworthy proclamation — he did not arrive at the episcopate suddenly, but, promoted through all the ecclesiastical offices, and having often deserved well of the Lord in the divine administrations, he ascended to the lofty summit of the priesthood through all the steps of religious service. Then further, he neither asked for the episcopate itself nor wished it, nor did he seize it as others do whom the swelling of their own arrogance and pride inflates; but quiet otherwise, and modest, and such as those are wont to be who are divinely chosen for this place, in keeping with the modesty of his virginal continence and the humility of his inborn and well-guarded reverence, he did not, as some do, use force to become bishop, but himself suffered force, so that he received the episcopate under compulsion. And he was made bishop by very many of our colleagues who were then present in the city of Rome, who sent to us letters concerning his ordination, honorable and laudatory and distinguished by the testimony of their proclamation. And Cornelius was made bishop by the judgment of God and of His Christ, by the testimony of almost all the clergy, by the suffrage of the people who were then present, and by the college of venerable priests and good men — when no one had been made before him, when the place of Fabian, that is, the place of Peter and the rank of the sacerdotal chair, stood vacant. And this place being occupied, and confirmed by the will of God and the consent of all of us, whoever now wishes to be made bishop must necessarily be made outside; nor does he have ecclesiastical ordination who does not hold the unity of the Church. Whoever he may be — though boasting much about himself and claiming very much for himself — he

<i>Latin (CSEL III.2)</i>	<i>English</i>
profanus est, alienus est, foris est. et cum post primum secundus esse non possit, quisque post unum qui solus esse debeat factus est iam non secundus ille sed nullus est.	is profane, he is alien, he is outside. And since after the first there cannot be a second, whoever is made after the one who ought to be alone is now not second, but null.

Chapter 9 — Cornelius fearless in the chair of Rome (CSEL p. 630)

<i>Latin (CSEL III.2)</i>	<i>English</i>
Tunc deinde post episcopatum non exambitum nec extortum, sed de Dei qui sacerdotes facit uoluntate susceptum, quanta in ipso suscepto episcopatu suo uirtus, quantum robur animi, qualis firmitas fidei, quod nos simplici corde et perspicere penitus et laudare debemus, sedisse intrepidum Romae in sacerdotali cathedra eo tempore cum tyrannus infestus sacerdotibus Dei fanda adque infanda comminaretur, cum multo patientius et tolerabilius audiret leuari aduersus se aemulum principem quam constitui Romae Dei sacerdotem. [...]	Then further, after an episcopate neither canvassed for nor extorted, but received from the will of God who makes priests — what virtue there was in his very acceptance of his episcopate, what strength of soul, what firmness of faith! — a thing we ought with simple heart both to perceive thoroughly and to praise: that he sat fearless at Rome in the sacerdotal chair at that time when a tyrant, hostile to the priests of God, was uttering threats speakable and unspeakable — when he would hear with far more patience and tolerance that a rival prince was being raised up against himself, than that a priest of God was established at Rome. [...]

Chapter 24 — Novatian, self-made against the world's episcopate, is no bishop (CSEL pp. 642–643)

<i>Latin (CSEL III.2)</i>	<i>English</i>
Quod uero ad Nouatiani personam pertinet, frater carissime, de quo desiderasti tibi scribi quam haeresim introduxisset, scias nos primo in loco nec curiosos esse debere quid ille doceat, cum foris doceat. quisque ille est et qualiscumque est, christianus non est qui in Christi ecclesia non est. iacet se licet et philosophiam uel eloquentiam	But as to what concerns the person of Novatian, dearest brother — about whom you desired that it be written to you what heresy he had introduced — know that in the first place we ought not even to be curious as to what he teaches, since he teaches outside. Whoever he is and of whatever sort he is, he is not a Christian who is not in the Church of Christ. Though he boast of himself and proclaim his philosophy and his

<i>Latin (CSEL III.2)</i>	<i>English</i>
suam superbis uocibus praedicet, qui nec fraternam caritatem nec ecclesiasticam unitatem tenuit etiam quod prius fuerat amisit. nisi si episcopus tibi uidetur qui, episcopo in ecclesia a sedecim coepiscopis facto, adulter adque extraneus episcopus fieri a desertoribus per ambitum nititur, et cum sit a Christo una ecclesia per totum mundum in multa membra diuisa, item episcopatus unus episcoporum multorum concordii numerositate diffusus, ille post Dei traditionem, post conexam et ubique coniunctam catholicae ecclesiae unitatem humanam conetur ecclesiam facere et per plurimas ciuitates nouos apostolos suos mittat, ut quaedam recentia institutionis suae fundamenta constituat, cumque iam pridem per omnes prouincias et per urbes singulas ordinati sint episcopi in aetate antiqui, in fide integri, in pressura probati, in persecutione proscripti, ille super eos creare alios pseudoeπισcopos audeat: quasi possit aut totum orbem noui conatus obstinatione peragraré aut ecclesiastici corporis compaginem discordiae suae seminatione rescindere, nesciens schismaticos semper inter initia feruere, incrementa uero habere non posse nec augere quod inlicité coeperint, sed statim cum praua sua aemulatione deficere. Episcopatum autem tenere non posset, etiam si episcopus prius factus a coepiscoporum suorum corpore et ab ecclesiae unitate descisceret, quando apostolus admoneat ut inuicem nosmet ipsos sustineamus, ne ab unitate quam Deus constituit recedamus, et dicat: sustinentes	eloquence with proud words, he who has kept neither brotherly charity nor ecclesiastical unity has lost even what he formerly was. Unless he seems to you a bishop who — when a bishop had been made in the Church by sixteen fellow bishops — strives by intrigue to be made an adulterous and alien bishop at the hands of deserters; and although there is from Christ one Church, divided through the whole world into many members, and likewise one episcopate, spread abroad in the concordant multiplicity of many bishops, he, after God's tradition, after the bound-together and everywhere-conjoined unity of the catholic Church, attempts to make a human church, and sends his new apostles through very many cities, to lay some fresh foundations of an institution of his own; and although through all the provinces and through every single city bishops have long since been ordained — ancient in age, sound in faith, proved in trial, proscribed in persecution — he dares to create over them other pseudo- bishops: as though he could either traverse the whole world with the obstinacy of his new endeavor, or tear apart the fabric of the ecclesiastical body by the sowing of his discord — not knowing that schismatics always seethe at the beginning, but cannot have growth, nor increase what they have unlawfully begun, but fail at once together with their own perverse rivalry. But he could not hold the episcopate even if he had first been made bishop and afterwards seceded from the body of his fellow bishops and from the unity of the Church; since the Apostle admonishes us to bear with one another, lest we withdraw from the unity which God has established, and says: "Bearing with one another

<i>Latin (CSEL III.2)</i>	<i>English</i>
inuicem in dilectione, satis agentes seruare unitatem spiritus in coniunctione pacis. qui ergo nec unitatem spiritus nec coniunctionem pacis obseruat et se ab ecclesiae uinculo adque a sacerdotum collegio separat, episcopi nec potestatem potest habere nec honorem qui episcopatus nec unitatem uoluit tenere nec pacem.	in love, taking care to preserve the unity of the spirit in the bond of peace.” He therefore who observes neither the unity of the spirit nor the bond of peace, and separates himself from the tie of the Church and from the college of priests, can have neither the power of a bishop nor his honor, since he has willed to keep neither the unity of the episcopate nor its peace.